Hinduism and Buddhism – such as the Sri Vijaya Empire in present-day Cambodia, Thailand and Indonesia (Java) during the seventh century.

The makers of modern India have often sought inspiration from their country's long history. Most Indians believe that India and Indians have a rich inheritance, including philosophies and ideas, and contemporary India can only grow under the shadow of its past. This general principle, of the present being guided by the past and the future only reflecting it, also applies to the realm of foreign policy.

For example, Kotha Satchidananda Murty, an Indian philosopher and professor, compares and contrasts Indian philosophical streams with those of the West. Writing in the 1960s, Murty asserts there were two philosophical streams in Indian foreign policy, one realist and the other idealist or moralist. Murty traces Indian realism to ancient treatises like the *Arthasastra*s, *Dharmasastra*s and *Nitisastra*s and refers to this as the 'positivistic Kautilyan theory'.[4] A key element of Indian realism was that this theory was applicable only for 'states within India' and did not apply beyond the subcontinent.

For Murty, the idealistic and moralistic stream in Indian politics comes from Buddhism and Jainism. Murty refers to this as the 'autochthonous and moralistic Ashokan theory' and according to him, these views were intended to have 'universal application' in contrast with locally applicable Indian realism. [5] Ashoka (269–232 BC) was the greatest emperor of the Mauryan dynasty who embraced Buddhism and attempted to govern according to his new religion's humanitarian tenets.

Murty divides ancient Indian realists into two groups: the '*Arthasastrins*' and the '*Dharmasastrins*.' Those he refers to as the Arthasastrians, or the followers of Kautilya, were akin to 'Machiavelli's "foxes"' who 'recommend artifice, infiltration, subversion, propaganda and economic pressure in preference to war which was always risky and expensive'.[6] Opposed to them were the Dharmasastrins, or those who follow Manu, who